

BUSLINK OPERATOR HANDBOOK

Official Partner Manual for Fleet Operations, Route Scheduling, Fares, Settlements & Service Compliance

Document Reference:	BLK-OPH-2026-V3.0
Effective Date:	August 1, 2026
Issuing Directorate:	Directorate of Fleet Operations & Partner Relations
Target Audience:	Registered Bus Operators, Fleet Managers & Station Masters
Document Security:	Confidential Commercial Operating Manual

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SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION AND PLATFORM OVERVIEW

1.1 Purpose of the Operator Handbook

The BusLink Operator Handbook ('Handbook') serves as the authoritative operational manual, regulatory guide, and standard operating procedure (SOP) reference for commercial transport operators, fleet managers, and station personnel operating on the BusLink platform. This document defines the commercial agreements, technical requirements, passenger service expectations, financial reconciliation policies, and legal compliance obligations necessary to maintain active, high-performing partner status across regional and national highway transit networks.

1.2 Scope of Partner Operations

This Handbook governs all partner activities conducted under the BusLink operational umbrella across intercity transit corridors. The scope encompasses initial fleet onboarding, vehicle compliance auditing, route registration, timetable scheduling, dynamic fare management, seat inventory allocation, passenger boarding logistics, refund management, financial settlements, and dispute resolution.

1.3 Intended Audience

This document is prepared specifically for:

- Executive Leadership & Managing Directors of Bus Transport Companies.
- Fleet Operations Managers & Route Coordinators.
- Terminal Station Masters & Highway Hub Supervisors.
- Onboard Bus Conductors, Drivers, and Maintenance Engineers.
- Finance, Accounts, and Audit Compliance Personnel.

1.4 About the BusLink Platform

BusLink is India's leading commercial intercity bus transportation network. BusLink empowers independent bus operators through sophisticated fleet management technology, automated ticket inventory distribution, dynamic fare optimization, centralized passenger communication, and transparent financial settlements. By connecting partner operators with millions of daily travelers, BusLink ensures maximum fleet occupancy, operational predictability, and superior passenger safety standards.

SECTION 2: BECOMING A BUSLINK OPERATOR

2.1 Commercial Eligibility Criteria

To qualify for registration as a BusLink partner operator, an entity must satisfy the following commercial and legal prerequisites:

- Business Entity: Must be a legally registered commercial entity (Sole Proprietorship, Registered Partnership Firm, LLP, or Private/Public Limited Company).
- Transport Permits: Must hold valid State Transport Authority (STA) or Regional Transport Office (RTO) Stage Carriage or Contract Carriage Permits.

- Minimum Fleet Size: Must own or operate a minimum commercial fleet of at least one (1) heavy passenger motor vehicle in roadworthy condition.
- Commercial Insurance: Must maintain active comprehensive commercial motor insurance and statutory third-party liability coverage across all fleet vehicles.
- Tax & Banking: Must possess an active Goods and Services Tax (GSTIN) registration and a dedicated commercial bank account matching the registered entity name.

2.2 Step-by-Step Operator Registration Process

Stage 1: Digital Application Submission – The operator registers basic company details, director information, and commercial contact numbers.

Stage 2: Document Upload & Verification – Uploading scanned PDF copies of all statutory business, tax, banking, and transport permits.

Stage 3: Compliance & Legal Audit – BusLink Compliance Officers audit submitted documents against official government databases (Vahan/Sarathi registries).

Stage 4: Physical / Virtual Fleet Audit – Inspection of vehicle physical condition, emergency exit functionality, seat layout, and onboard amenities.

Stage 5: Partnership Agreement Execution & Account Activation – Signing the Master Commercial Agreement and issuing active operator portal credentials.

2.3 Required Business Documentation Checklist

- Certificate of Business Incorporation / Firm Registration Certificate.
- Commercial Tax Registration (GSTIN Certificate).
- Entity Permanent Account Number (PAN) Card.
- RTO Stage Carriage / Tourist Omnibus Permit Copies for each vehicle.
- Vehicle Registration Certificates (RC Smart Cards).
- Valid Fitness Certificates issued by authorized RTO testing stations.
- Comprehensive Commercial Vehicle Insurance Policy Certificates.
- Cancelled Cheque / Bank Account Confirmation Letter for automated settlements.

2.4 Verification Timelines

Document verification and fleet audits are completed within 48 to 72 hours of complete application submission.

2.5 Primary Reasons for Application Rejection

- Expired or lapsed vehicle fitness certificates, insurance policies, or RTO permits.
- Name mismatch between commercial registration, GSTIN certificate, and bank account.
- Submitting low-resolution, illegible, or modified document scans.
- Prior history of severe safety violations, permit cancellations, or transport authority blacklisting.

2.6 Re-Application Procedure

Rejected applicants receive a detailed rejection notice specifying non-compliant items. Operators may rectify deficiencies and resubmit within 14 business days without incurring re-application fees.

Summary Table: Document Verification & Compliance Matrix

Document Name	Issuing Authority	Validity Period
Vehicle Registration (RC)	Regional Transport Office (RTO)	15 Years Initial / 5-Yr Renewal
Stage / Contract Permit	State Transport Authority (STA)	5 Years / Annual Permit Fee
Commercial Insurance	IRDAI Approved Insurer	Annual Mandatory Renewal
RTO Fitness Certificate	Authorized RTO Testing Station	Annual Mandatory Renewal

SECTION 3: OPERATOR ACCOUNT MANAGEMENT

3.1 Maintaining Profile & Business Credentials

Operators must keep their company profile up to date at all times. Any change in corporate office address, management personnel, GSTIN status, or banking details must be reported to BusLink within 48 hours.

3.2 Station Master & Operational Contact Directory

Each operator must register a 24/7 Operational Helpline, a Night Dispatch Supervisor, and Station Masters for every major terminal hub served.

3.3 Automated Document Renewal Tracking

The BusLink portal monitors document expiration dates (Permits, Insurance, Fitness). Operators receive automated email and SMS reminders at 30 days, 15 days, and 7 days prior to document expiration.

CRITICAL COMPLIANCE NOTICE: If a vehicle's Insurance, Fitness, or RTO Permit expires, the system automatically deactivates that vehicle from trip scheduling until valid renewal documents are uploaded and approved.

3.4 Account Status Classification

- **Active:** Fully verified, compliant, and authorized to schedule trips and collect ticket revenue.
- **Pending Audit:** Document updates or new fleet additions undergoing compliance review.
- **Temporarily Suspended:** Listing rights suspended due to expired documents, unresolved passenger grievances, or low rating scores.
- **Inactive / Terminated:** Partnership agreement formally dissolved.

3.5 Temporary Suspension Protocols

BusLink reserves the right to suspend operator listing rights if:

- **Operational On-Time Performance (OTP)** falls below 80% over a 30-day period.
- **Unannounced trip cancellations** exceed 3% of scheduled departures in a calendar month.

- Vehicle cleanliness or safety complaints exceed acceptable operational thresholds.

3.6 Voluntary Account Closure

Operators seeking voluntary termination must submit a 30-day formal written notice. All existing passenger bookings scheduled within the 30-day window must be fulfilled in complete compliance with BusLink quality standards.

SECTION 4: BUS FLEET MANAGEMENT

4.1 Vehicle Registration & Specs Verification

Every vehicle must be individually registered on the portal prior to assigning it to active routes. Required details include:

- Vehicle Registration Number (e.g., KA-01-F-9988).
- Chassis & Engine Numbers.
- Vehicle Manufacturer, Model, and Year of Manufacture.
- Vehicle Category (AC Sleeper, Non-AC Sleeper, AC Seater, Multi-Axle Volvo/Scania/BharatBenz).
- Approved Seating / Sleeper Berth Capacity.

4.2 Vehicle Classification Standards

1. Ultra-Luxury Multi-Axle AC Sleeper: Twin-axle coach with individual air-conditioned sleeper berths, privacy curtains, reading lights, USB charging, and air suspension.
2. Executive AC Seater (2x2 / 2x1): Reclining push-back seats with calf supports, footrests, and central entertainment.
3. Standard AC/Non-AC Sleeper: Upper and lower sleeper berths designed for overnight highway transit.
4. Express Semi-Sleeper: High-capacity comfortable seating for short-to-medium intercity corridors.

4.3 Mandatory Onboard Amenities Declaration

Operators must accurately declare available amenities during bus setup (e.g., Air Conditioning, High-Speed Wi-Fi, Individual Charging Ports, Blankets/Pillows, Water Bottles, Onboard Toilet, Emergency Glass Hammers, AIS-140 GPS). Misrepresenting amenities triggers automatic financial penalties upon passenger complaint validation.

4.4 Fleet Image Upload Standards

Operators must upload high-resolution photos displaying:

- Full exterior side profile with clearly visible registration plate.
- Interior cabin view from front aisle showing seat/berth quality.
- Close-up view of individual sleeper berth or seating comfort.

4.5 Vehicle Status Controls

- Active: Mechanically fit and available for route assignment.
- Maintenance: Vehicle undergoing routine servicing, mechanical repairs, or bodywork.
- Decommissioned: Vehicle permanently retired from active fleet service.

SECTION 5: ROUTE MANAGEMENT

5.1 Creating Operator-Specific Routes

Operators can create origin-destination route corridors corresponding to their authorized transport permits. Each route record defines:

- Origin City & Destination City (e.g., Bengaluru to Hyderabad).
- Total Highway Distance (in Kilometers).
- Estimated Total Travel Time (in Hours & Minutes).
- Primary Boarding Terminals and Pickup Waypoints.
- Final Drop Terminals and Intermediate Drop Points.

5.2 Boarding & Drop Point Configuration

Operators must specify exact physical landmarks, station master contacts, and reporting times for every pickup point along the route:

- Example Boarding Point: Bengaluru – Majestic (Opp. KSRTC Bus Stand Gate 3) | Reporting Time: 09:30 PM.
- Example Drop Point: Hyderabad – Lakdikapul (Near Pillar No. 12) | Estimated Drop Time: 06:00 AM.

5.3 Route Modification Restrictions

Modifications to established boarding points or route paths must be submitted at least 24 hours prior to departure to ensure passenger notifications are delivered smoothly.

5.4 Operator Route Isolation Policy

Routes created by an operator are strictly isolated to their operator account. Operators manage, price, and schedule trips exclusively on their authorized route network.

SECTION 6: TRIP & SCHEDULE MANAGEMENT

6.1 Scheduling Active Trips

A 'Trip' is a specific, bookable instance of a route assigned to a registered bus vehicle on a designated departure date and time.

6.2 Timetable Configuration

Operators configure exact departure and arrival timetables for each trip:

- Departure Date & Time from Origin Terminal.

- Estimated Arrival Date & Time at Destination Terminal.
- Base Ticket Price per seat/berth category.

6.3 Recurring & Automated Timetables

Operators can configure automated recurring schedules (e.g., Daily Express, Mon-Fri Executive, Weekend Special) up to 90 days in advance to capture advance customer bookings.

6.4 Festival & Holiday Surge Scheduling

During peak holiday periods (Diwali, Dussehra, Christmas, New Year), operators may schedule additional surge trips to capture high passenger volume.

6.5 Trip Cancellation Protocol

Canceling a trip with active passenger bookings is strictly regulated. Operators MUST notify BusLink at least 12 hours prior to scheduled departure and provide valid justification (e.g., mechanical failure without backup vehicle). Unjustified trip cancellations incur financial penalties and passenger compensation obligations.

SECTION 7: FARE MANAGEMENT AND DYNAMIC PRICING

7.1 Setting Commercial Base Fares

Operators maintain full commercial autonomy to establish base ticket prices for their routes and seat categories, subject to state transport regulatory caps.

7.2 Dynamic & Demand-Based Fare Strategies

Operators may adjust ticket prices dynamically based on demand, seasonal rush, or time-to-departure thresholds:

- Early Bird Discount: 10% lower fare for bookings made 15+ days in advance.
- Weekend Surge: 15% to 25% price adjustment for Friday and Sunday evening departures.
- Last-Minute Seat Clearance: Promotional fare drops 3 hours prior to departure to maximize fill factor.

7.3 Seating Category Price Differentials

- Lower Sleeper Berths vs. Upper Sleeper Berths (Lower berths priced 10-15% higher).
- Single Sleeper Berths vs. Double Sleeper Berths.
- Front-row seating vs. rear seating.

Summary Table: Dynamic Fare Strategy Guidelines

Pricing Scenario	Adjustment Strategy	Objective
Advance Booking (15+ Days)	10% Discount on Base Fare	Encourage early commitments
Weekend Surge (Fri/Sun)	15% to 25% Increase	Maximize peak demand yield

Festival Rush	Up to Regulatory Ceiling	Capture peak volume revenue
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SECTION 8: SEAT MANAGEMENT AND BLOCKING PROTOCOLS

8.1 Standard Seat Layout Templates

Operators select from pre-approved layout templates during vehicle setup:

- 2x2 Seater Layout (40 to 49 seats)
- 2x1 Sleeper Layout (30 to 36 berths)
- Hybrid 2x1 Seater-Cum-Sleeper (Lower seating, upper berths)

8.2 Real-Time Seat Status Categories

- Available: Seat open for public online booking.
- Booked: Confirmed reservation with issued PNR.
- Blocked: Seat temporarily held by operator for offline counter booking or conductor use.
- Female Reserved: Seat reserved exclusively for female passengers.

8.3 Operator Seat Blocking Protocol

Operators may block up to 4 seats per trip for quota or conductor emergency management. Blocked seats MUST be released at least 2 hours prior to departure if unutilized.

SECTION 9: BOOKING MANAGEMENT AND MANIFESTS

9.1 Real-Time Booking Tracking

Operators access real-time booking lists for all scheduled trips through the operator portal dashboard. Each booking record includes:

- 10-Character Alpha-Numeric PNR Code.
- Passenger Full Name, Age, Gender & Mobile Number.
- Assigned Seat/Berth Number.
- Selected Boarding Point & Drop Point.
- Total Fare Paid & Booking Timestamp.

9.2 Passenger Manifest Generation

Prior to departure, operators must generate and print the official Passenger Trip Manifest for the conductor. The manifest serves as the legal passenger register for RTO highway checkpoints.

9.3 Passenger Contact Restrictions

Passenger phone numbers on manifests are restricted strictly for boarding coordination and delay alerts. Contacting passengers for marketing or unauthorized purposes is strictly prohibited.

SECTION 10: CANCELLATION AND REFUND RESPONSIBILITIES

10.1 Customer Cancellation Refund Scale

When a customer cancels a confirmed ticket booking, refunds are automatically processed according to the standardized BusLink cancellation matrix:

- Cancellation > 24 hours prior to departure: 90% Refund (10% Cancellation Fee).
- Cancellation between 12 to 24 hours prior to departure: 75% Refund (25% Cancellation Fee).
- Cancellation between 4 to 12 hours prior to departure: 50% Refund (50% Cancellation Fee).
- Cancellation < 4 hours prior to departure: 0% Refund (100% Forfeiture).

10.2 Operator-Initiated Cancellation Penalties

If an operator cancels a trip due to operational failure:

- 100% Full Refund is immediately returned to all ticketed passengers.
- The operator pays a 15% platform disruption penalty per canceled seat.
- BusLink assists stranded passengers in securing alternative transport where feasible.

SECTION 11: REVENUE AND FINANCIAL SETTLEMENT

11.1 Settlement Accounting Framework

BusLink operates a transparent weekly financial settlement cycle for all completed passenger trips.

11.2 Revenue Calculation Formula

Net Operator Settlement = Gross Ticket Revenue – Platform Commission (e.g., 8%) – Applicable Tax Deductions – Refund Adjustments + Surge Incentives.

11.3 Settlement Disbursement Schedule

- Weekly Accounting Cycle: Trips completed between Monday 00:00 AM and Sunday 23:59 PM are reconciled on Monday.
- Bank Payout: Direct NEFT/RTGS transfer credited to operator's verified bank account every Wednesday morning.

11.4 Financial Statements & GST Tax Invoices

Operators can download automated weekly settlement statements, GST tax credit invoices, and annual revenue ledgers directly from the portal finance module.

Summary Table: Sample Operator Weekly Revenue Settlement Calculation

Accounting Line Item	Calculation Component	Sample Amount (INR)
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Gross Ticket Sales	500 Booked Passengers @ INR 800 avg	INR 4,00,000
Less: Platform Commission (8%)	8% of Gross Sales	- INR 32,000
Less: Refund Adjustments	Customer Cancellations (Tiered)	- INR 12,000
Less: Statutory Tax Deductions	TCS / TDS as per tax law	- INR 4,000
NET BANK PAYOUT	Direct Credit to Operator Bank	INR 3,52,000

SECTION 12: RATINGS, REVIEWS, AND SERVICE QUALITY

12.1 Passenger Review Mechanism

Upon journey completion, verified passengers rate their trip experience from 1.0 to 5.0 stars across four core parameters:

1. On-Time Performance (Punctuality of departure and arrival).
2. Bus Cleanliness & Hygiene (Sanitization of seats, berths, and cabin).
3. Staff Behavior & Professional Decorum (Driver and conductor courtesy).
4. Comfort & Amenities (Working AC, Wi-Fi, charging ports, suspension quality).

12.2 Operator Feedback Responses

Operators can view passenger reviews in real time and post professional public responses to constructive feedback.

12.3 Fleet Ranking Impact

Coaches maintaining high average ratings (4.2 stars and above) receive 'Top Rated Partner' badges and priority search placement on the passenger booking platform.

SECTION 13: SERVICE QUALITY STANDARDS

13.1 Vehicle Hygiene Protocol

- Thorough interior vacuuming, floor washing, and window cleaning prior to every departure.
- Freshly laundered, sanitized linen and sealed blankets provided for sleeper berths.
- Odorless, sanitized cabin environment with regular air freshener maintenance.

13.2 Crew Decorum & Uniform Policy

- Drivers and conductors must wear clean, prescribed operator uniforms and photo ID badges.
- Zero tolerance for smoking, chewing tobacco, or consuming alcohol while on duty.

- Courteous communication with passengers during boarding and comfort stops.

13.3 On-Time Performance (OTP) Commitment

Operators must maintain an overall OTP rating of at least 90%. Unjustified delays exceeding 30 minutes impact operator quality scores.

SECTION 14: COMPLIANCE AND LEGAL RESPONSIBILITIES

14.1 Statutory Transportation Compliance

Operators must strictly adhere to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules (CMVR), State Transport Authority guidelines, and speed governor regulations (Max 80 km/h on expressways).

14.2 Accurate Information Mandate

Misrepresenting bus types, seat counts, or amenities constitutes a breach of contract and triggers automatic passenger refund deductions.

14.3 Passenger Safety & Speed Limits

All vehicles must be equipped with functional AIS-140 GPS tracking devices, emergency panic buttons, and speed limiters.

SECTION 15: OPERATIONAL BEST PRACTICES

15.1 Route & Schedule Optimization

Analyze seasonal passenger demand data to optimize departure timings and maximize seat fill factors.

15.2 Preventive Vehicle Maintenance

Conduct routine mechanical inspections (tyre tread depth, brake fluid, engine oil, AC filters) every 5,000 km to prevent highway breakdowns.

15.3 Proactive Passenger Communication

Send automated SMS updates to passengers 1 hour prior to departure with driver phone numbers and boarding location reminders.

SECTION 16: COMMON OPERATIONAL SCENARIOS & SOPS

Scenario 1: Bus Breakdown Prior to Departure

SOP Action: Immediately dispatch a backup vehicle of equal or higher category. If backup delay exceeds 45 minutes, notify passengers via SMS and provide complimentary terminal refreshments.

Scenario 2: En-Route Highway Breakdown

SOP Action: Driver safely pulls to highway shoulder, activates hazard lights, and informs Control. Dispatch replacement coach within 90 minutes. Conductor assists passengers with luggage transfer.

Scenario 3: Unexpected Route Diversion / Landslide

SOP Action: Driver takes authorized alternative highway route. Conductor informs passengers of revised arrival ETA. Update Operations Control.

Scenario 4: Heavy Traffic Delay Exceeding 60 Minutes

SOP Action: Conductor makes cabin announcement explaining delay. Control broadcasts SMS updates to destination contacts.

Scenario 5: Passenger No-Show at Boarding Gate

SOP Action: Conductor calls passenger mobile twice. Wait until gate closure cutoff (10 mins prior). Coach departs on schedule. Mark passenger as No-Show.

Scenario 6: Duplicate Seat Booking Claim

SOP Action: Conductor checks PNR on digital manifest. If genuine system error, upgrade affected passenger to vacant higher category berth or arrange conductor backup berth. Report incident to support.

Scenario 7: En-Route Driver Replacement

SOP Action: Secondary certified relief driver takes steering immediately at designated highway depot.

Scenario 8: Overbooking Prevention Protocol

SOP Action: Real-time inventory sync prevents double booking. Offline counter bookings must use designated blocked seats.

SECTION 17: FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (55 FAQs)

Q1: How do I register as a new operator on BusLink?

A: Submit your business credentials, GST certificate, and fleet details via the operator portal for compliance audit.

Q2: How long does operator document verification take?

A: Verification typically takes 2 to 3 business days upon uploading complete, legible documents.

Q3: What documents are required for bus registration?

A: RC Book, RTO Fitness Certificate, Stage/Contract Permit, Commercial Insurance, and Pollution Certificate (PUC).

Q4: What happens if my vehicle insurance expires?

A: The system automatically deactivates the vehicle from trip scheduling until valid renewed insurance is uploaded.

Q5: Can I register a non-AC bus on BusLink?

A: Yes, both AC and Non-AC seater and sleeper coaches holding valid permits can be registered.

Q6: How are ticket prices decided?

A: Operators have full commercial freedom to set base prices and dynamic fares within state regulatory limits.

Q7: When do I receive revenue settlements for completed trips?

A: Revenue payouts are credited directly to your bank account every Wednesday for the preceding week's trips.

Q8: What is BusLink's platform commission fee?

A: Platform commission typically ranges between 6% and 10% depending on route volume and agreement tier.

Q9: How can I view real-time bookings for my bus?

A: Log into the operator portal dashboard or mobile operator app to view real-time passenger manifests.

Q10: What should I do if a bus breaks down before departure?

A: Provide an equivalent backup coach immediately. If unable, notify BusLink to issue 100% full refunds.

Q11: Can I block seats for offline counter sales?

A: Yes, operators can manually block up to 4 seats per trip, which must be released 2 hours prior to departure.

Q12: How are passenger refunds handled for customer cancellations?

A: Refunds follow the automated tiered scale (90% >24h, 75% 12-24h, 50% 4-12h, 0% <4h).

Q13: Can I change a boarding point 2 hours before departure?

A: No, boarding point changes require at least 24 hours advance notice to protect passenger logistics.

Q14: What is the penalty for canceling a trip with short notice?

A: Canceling a trip within 12 hours incurs a 15% platform disruption penalty per booked seat.

Q15: How can I improve my bus star rating?

A: Ensure strict departure punctuality, clean sanitized linen, polite staff behavior, and working AC/charging ports.

Q16: Are driver details mandatory on passenger manifests?

A: Yes, driver name, license number, and contact mobile must be listed on the conductor trip manifest.

Q17: What is the maximum speed limit for BusLink fleet coaches?

A: Speed governors must be calibrated to maximum 80 km/h as mandated by highway transport rules.

Q18: How do I handle lost luggage claims from passengers?

A: Deposit retrieved items at the destination terminal Lost & Found office and log details in the portal.

Q19: Can I offer promotional discount codes for my routes?

A: Yes, operators can configure promotional fare campaigns directly through the portal marketing tab.

Q20: What is the minimum average rating required to stay active?

A: Operators must maintain a minimum fleet average rating of 3.0 stars to avoid temporary suspension.

Q21: Can I add temporary seasonal coaches during festival rushes?

A: Yes, seasonal coaches with valid temporary permits can be onboarded within 24 hours.

Q22: How is GST handled on ticket bookings?

A: BusLink generates compliant GST tax invoices showing CGST/SGST/IGST breakdown for passenger tickets.

Q23: Who pays for highway toll charges?

A: Highway toll fees are borne directly by the operator as part of operational running expenses.

Q24: What happens if a passenger brings excess luggage?

A: Charge excess baggage fees according to the standard policy (INR 50/kg for 20-30 kg tier).

Q25: Can I restrict single female seat bookings next to male passengers?

A: Yes, the automated seating system reserves adjacent seats for females when a single female books.

Q26: What is the policy on driver duty hours?

A: Drivers must not exceed 8 continuous hours of steering without a mandatory 30-minute relief break.

Q27: How do I update my primary bank account details?

A: Submit a bank update request with a cancelled cheque copy in the portal finance tab for re-verification.

Q28: Can I operate routes across state borders?

A: Yes, provided your vehicle holds a valid All India Tourist Permit (AITP) or National Permit with state taxes paid.

Q29: How do I track passenger reviews for my fleet?

A: Access the 'Reviews & Ratings' module in the portal to monitor ratings and post official responses.

Q30: What safety equipment is mandatory onboard?

A: Certified Commercial First-Aid Kit, Dual 2 kg Fire Extinguishers, Emergency Break Hammers, and AIS-140 GPS.

Q31: Can I offer complimentary food packets on luxury sleeper routes?

A: Yes, declaring complimentary snacks/beverages enhances your amenity rating and search ranking.

Q32: How do I report a disruptive passenger?

A: Contact BusLink Operations Support and disembark disruptive passengers at the nearest highway police station.

Q33: Can I change the departure time of a trip after bookings have started?

A: Departure time changes after booking initiation are prohibited unless approved by Operations Support.

Q34: How are multi-passenger group bookings handled?

A: Up to 6 seats can be booked in a single PNR transaction.

Q35: What happens if a passenger claims a missing blanket?

A: Conductor should immediately provide a spare fresh blanket from the cabin emergency linen kit.

Q36: Can I list different fares for upper and lower berths?

A: Yes, differential pricing for lower sleeper berths, upper berths, and single berths is fully supported.

Q37: What is the procedure for updating vehicle seat layout?

A: Submit a layout modification request. The vehicle must undergo re-audit before new layout activation.

Q38: Are fuel surcharges allowed during diesel price spikes?

A: Base fares can be revised by the operator to reflect fuel price variations within regulatory limits.

Q39: How do I receive urgent operational alerts from BusLink?

A: Critical alerts are broadcast via SMS, WhatsApp Operator Channel, and Portal Push Notifications.

Q40: Can I temporarily pause a route during off-season?

A: Yes, set the route status to 'Inactive' in the portal. Unschedule future trips without penalty.

Q41: What is the protocol for severe weather alerts (floods/cyclones)?

A: BusLink Operations may issue temporary safety hold orders on affected corridors. Trips are rescheduled safely.

Q42: Can an operator assign two drivers for long journeys exceeding 500 km?

A: Yes! Journeys exceeding 500 km or 8 hours MUST carry dual certified drivers for shift rotation.

Q43: How do I download monthly financial tax summaries?

A: Navigate to Reports > Financial Ledger > Download Monthly GST Summary (PDF/Excel).

Q44: What constitutes misrepresentation of bus amenities?

A: Declaring Wi-Fi or AC when non-functional. Results in INR 200 compensation per passenger ticket.

Q45: How can I contact the Operator Support Desk?

A: Call the Dedicated Operator Support Helpline at 1800-BUS-OPS-1 or email partner@buslink.in.

Q46: Is driver alcohol testing mandatory before departure?

A: Yes, station masters must conduct breathalyzer tests prior to handing over trip manifests.

Q47: Can I transfer a vehicle to another registered operator?

A: Vehicle transfers require RTO NOC submission and re-verification under the recipient operator ID.

Q48: How are passenger complaints regarding AC failure resolved?

A: Partial refund (20% of fare) is issued to affected passengers if AC fails for more than 1 hour en-route.

Q49: What is the policy for carrying commercial cargo?

A: Unaccompanied commercial cargo is prohibited on passenger coaches. Hold space is reserved for passenger luggage.

Q50: Can I offer child discounts on ticket fares?

A: Yes, operators can configure child fare rules for children aged 2 to 12 years.

Q51: What happens if a coach arrives 2 hours late at destination?

A: Delayed arrival >2 hours due to operator fault impacts OTP score and incurs minor refund adjustments.

Q52: Are sleeper berth curtains mandatory?

A: Yes, clean flame-retardant privacy curtains must be fitted on all sleeper berth compartments.

Q53: How do I request a temporary waiver for emergency fleet maintenance?

A: Submit a maintenance ticket in portal with garage job card copy to waive cancellation penalties.

Q54: Can I view historical revenue reports for past years?

A: Yes, full historical financial reports are archived and accessible in the operator portal.

Q55: What is the ultimate goal of the BusLink Operator Partnership?

A: To deliver safe, reliable, profitable, and highly-rated intercity passenger transportation across India.

SECTION 18: OPERATIONAL GLOSSARY

- **Operator:** A legally registered commercial transport entity authorized to operate passenger coaches on BusLink.
- **Fleet:** The total collection of commercial bus vehicles registered and verified under an operator account.
- **Route:** An authorized origin-to-destination transport corridor specifying distance, duration, and pickup/drop waypoints.
- **Trip:** A single, scheduled instance of a route assigned to a specific bus vehicle on a designated date and time.
- **PNR (Passenger Name Record):** A unique 10-character code identifying a confirmed ticket booking.
- **Passenger Manifest:** The official legal register of ticketed passengers onboard a specific trip instance.
- **Settlement:** The weekly financial payout of net ticket revenue transferred from BusLink to the operator bank account.
- **Commission:** The platform service fee retained by BusLink for booking distribution and technology infrastructure.
- **Seat Layout:** The spatial seating diagram (2x2, 2x1, sleeper) defining vehicle seat positions and numbers.
- **No-Show:** A ticketed passenger who fails to report at the boarding gate prior to coach departure.
- **OTP (On-Time Performance):** The operational metric measuring punctuality of departures and arrivals.

SECTION 19: DOCUMENT REVISION HISTORY

This Handbook is periodically updated to reflect evolving transportation regulations, security standards, and operational workflows. Below is the document control log:

Document Revision History Table

Version	Release Date	Author / Department	Summary of Changes
1.0	15-Jan-2024	Partner Operations Dept	Initial Operator Onboarding Manual
2.0	10-Jan-2025	Fleet & Compliance Div	Added Dynamic Fares & Refund Matrices
3.0	01-Aug-2026	Directorate of Operations	Comprehensive Revision: 55 FAQs, SOPs & Revenue Models